SESSION 08

Cover and Table of Contents

Two thresholds a reviewer crosses before the work itself.

Portfolio as Narrative · Cover Typologies, Contents Typologies, and Page Numbering

Why Today Matters

The Cover Is the Threshold

- **The cover** is the first design decision a reviewer meets, and it frames every page that follows.
- **The table of contents** is the reader's first act of navigation. Its design shows them how to move through your work.
- Both should carry the same Red Thread and the same type system as the project pages.
- Tonight: seven cover patterns, six contents patterns, and one page numbering system.

BEFORE THE FIRST PROJECT

- **The cover** the position
- **The contents** the route
- **The numbering** the system

From Module 14: Cover and Table of Contents.

Learning Objectives

After this session, you will be able to:

1. **Read the seven cover typologies** and name the one closest to your project.

2. **Match a cover** to what the project argues and to the type system from Session 07.

3. **Read the six contents typologies** and pick the one that fits the length and structure of your portfolio.

4. **Apply one page numbering system** across the whole file, so the contents page and the project pages agree.

COVER

Purpose and Tone

Like an opening scene, the cover sets mood and expectation before anyone sees a project.

Minimal Approach

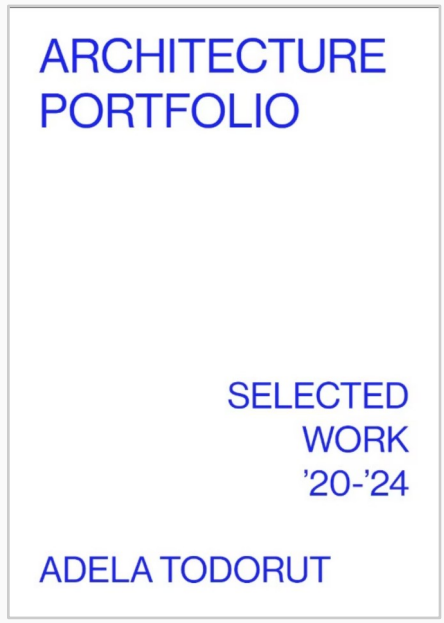
Clean typography and strategic white space convey sophistication and clarity. It suits portfolios built on precision and refined detail.

Bold Statement

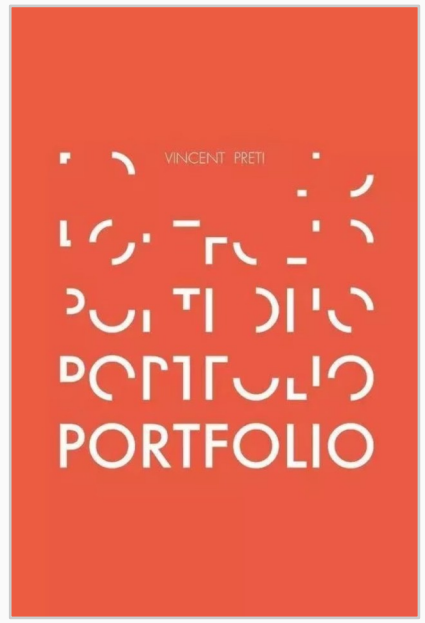
Strong colors, dramatic imagery, or oversized typography signal confidence and innovation. It suits experimental or cutting-edge work.

Conceptual Voice

Abstract elements or symbolic graphics hint at a deeper design philosophy. It works for theoretical or research-focused portfolios.



Minimal



Bold statement

Reference covers from the Crafting the Identity class.

COVER

Essential Cover Content

What the cover has to carry, and what it can leave out.

1

Name and Title

Always include your full name prominently. You can add "Architecture Portfolio" or a graduation year for context, but avoid redundant text that clutters the design.

2

Visual Elements

Choose between abstracted project details, minimal graphics that hint at your style, or bold typography alone. Each approach communicates a different design sensibility.

3

Optional Information

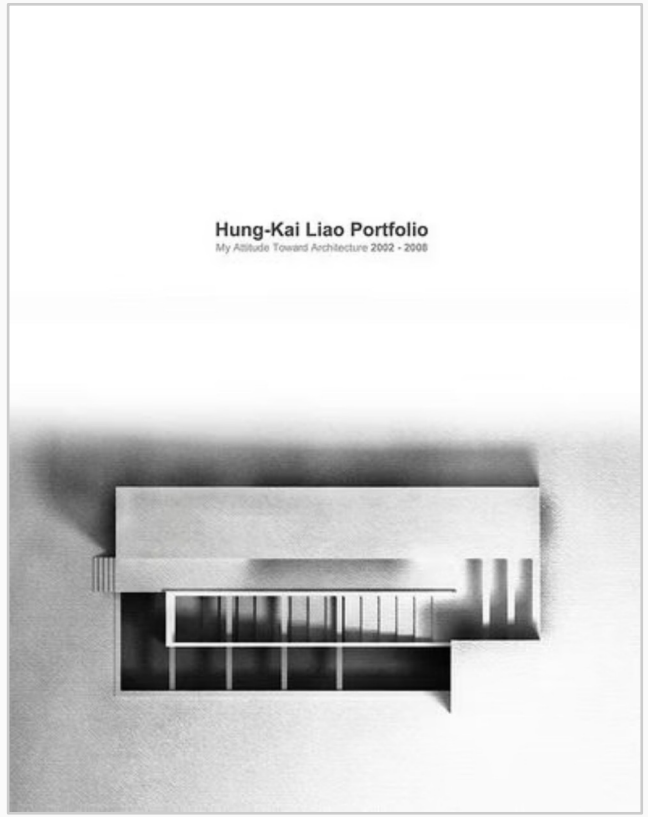
Include dates or institutional affiliations only when they strengthen your positioning. Context matters more than completeness.

COVER

Choosing the Image

A detail from your best project can be stronger than showing the whole design.

- **Abstract it.** Crop diagrams, model photos, or renderings to create intrigue without revealing everything.
- Focus on compelling geometries.
- Highlight material textures.
- Showcase unique construction details.
- **Or use type alone.** Sometimes strong typography carries more impact than any image. Let the overall tone of your portfolio decide.



A cropped model image with a small title.

COVER

Principles and Pitfalls

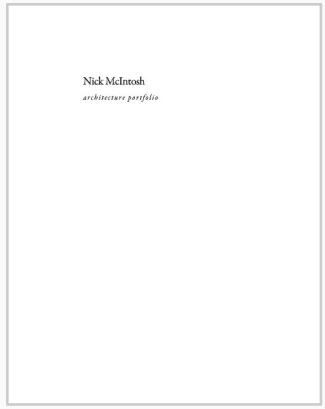
Three things to do and three to avoid.

PRINCIPLES	PITFALLS
Immediate Legibility Your name must read instantly. Avoid complex backgrounds or low contrast, and test it at thumbnail size.	**Generic Stock Images** Avoid cliché architectural photography or heavy textures that could belong to anyone's portfolio.
Typographic Consistency Use fonts that match your interior spreads, so the cover feels connected to the work inside.	**Style Disconnect** Do not make the cover so different from your interior pages that it feels disconnected. Coherence builds trust.
Color Psychology Black and white reads as minimal and timeless. Bold colors suggest energy and innovation. Muted tones suggest subtlety.	**Visual Overload** Resist including every design element you love. A cluttered cover overwhelms the reader.

COVER

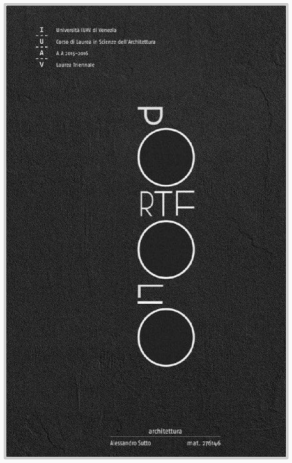
Seven Cover Typologies

Seven compositional patterns recur across architecture portfolio covers.



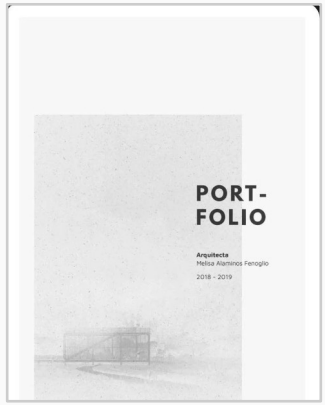
01 Pure Minimal

Type only



02 Dark Ground

Light type on dark



03 Hero Image

One dominant image



04 Bleed + Type Band

Image plus type band



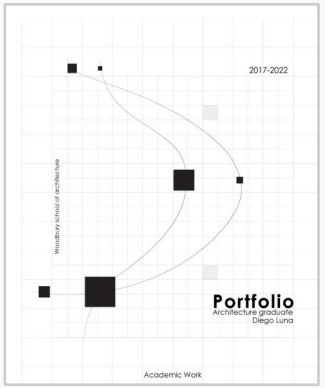
05 Scattered Collage

Many small images



06 Grid / Pattern

Repeating motif



07 Abstract Line

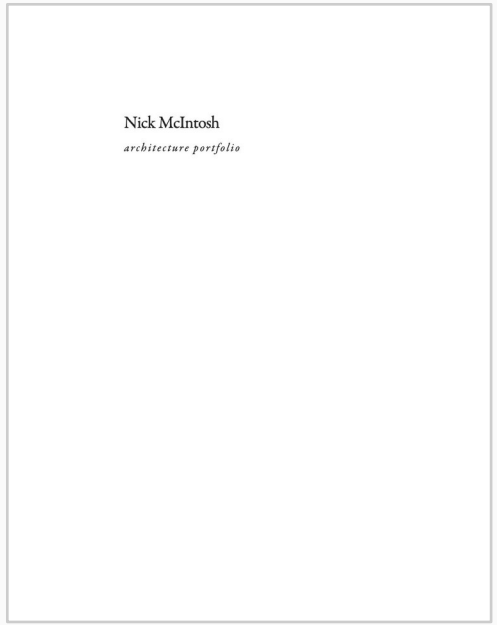
Lines and geometry

The question is which one fits your narrative, not which one looks best.

COVER TYPE 01

Pure Minimal

Maximum whitespace is the main compositional element, and typography is the only visual content.







Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.

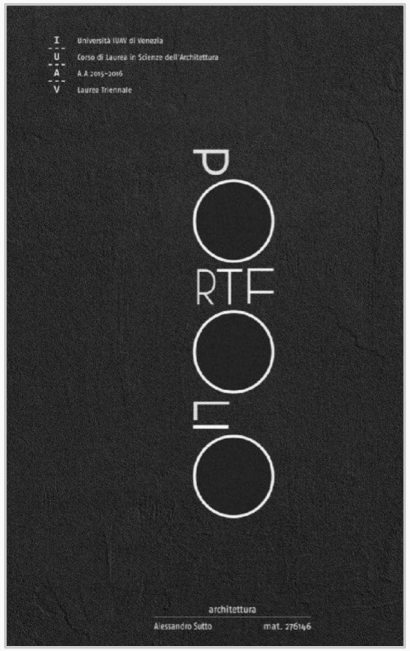
KEY PRINCIPLES

- Text takes less than 8% of the page. The whitespace is the design, not leftover space.
- The text cluster sits off center, usually toward the lower right, which creates diagonal tension across the field.
- Hierarchy lives in a compact cluster of about three lines: shifts in weight, size, and value.
- No imagery and no decoration. The confidence comes from restraint.

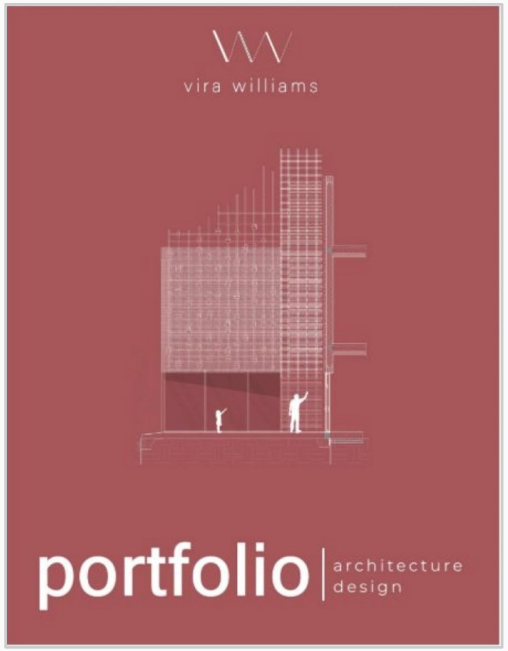
COVER TYPE 02

Dark Ground

Figure and ground invert: a dark surface with light typography.







Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.

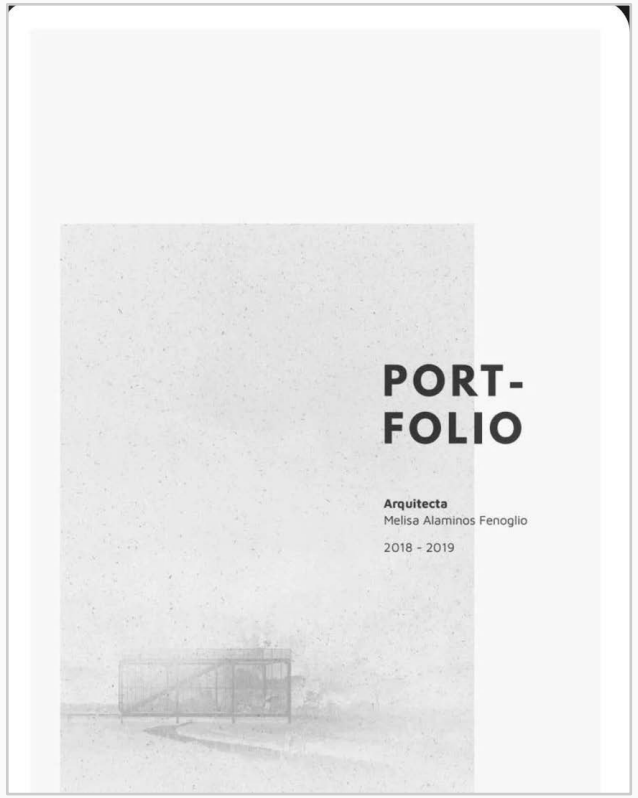
KEY PRINCIPLES

- The dark page becomes the active void and the light type becomes the figure.
- Texture, such as paper grain, concrete, or noise, gives the digital page a material presence.
- Letterforms are often broken apart, rescaled, or mixed with geometric shapes.
- The result is dramatic and atmospheric. It signals confidence and a conceptual design sensibility.

COVER TYPE 03

Hero Image

Three vertical bands with one dominant image as the anchor.





Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.

KEY PRINCIPLES

- Header about 17%, image about 58%, footer about 25%. The reading order is title, image, author.
- One image takes 55 to 65% of the page and carries the portfolio's identity.
- Text stays small and peripheral, anchoring the corners without competing with the image.
- Choose the image carefully. It has to represent your strongest or most characteristic project.

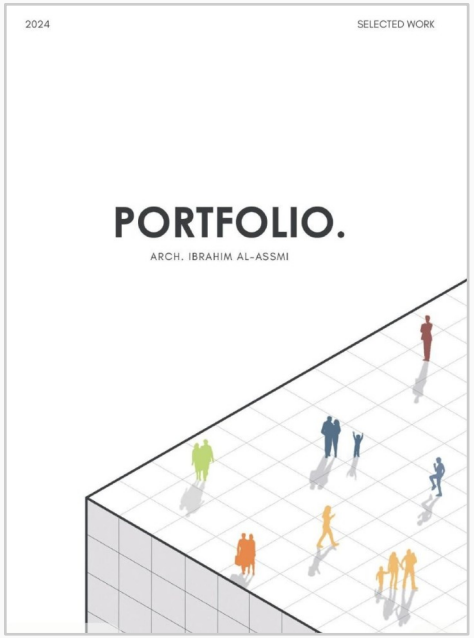
COVER TYPE 04

Bleed Image + Type Band

Two zones: an image that bleeds to the edges and a distinct band of type.







Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.

KEY PRINCIPLES

- Image zone 60 to 70%, type band 30 to 40%.
- The hard dividing edge between the zones creates the main tension. Never use a gradient or fade.
- The image bleeds to the page edges, which implies it continues beyond the frame.
- The band uses a bold title and corner anchors, such as an issue number or date, to balance the image.

COVER TYPE 05

Scattered Collage

Many images arranged at irregular spacing and variable scale.



Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.

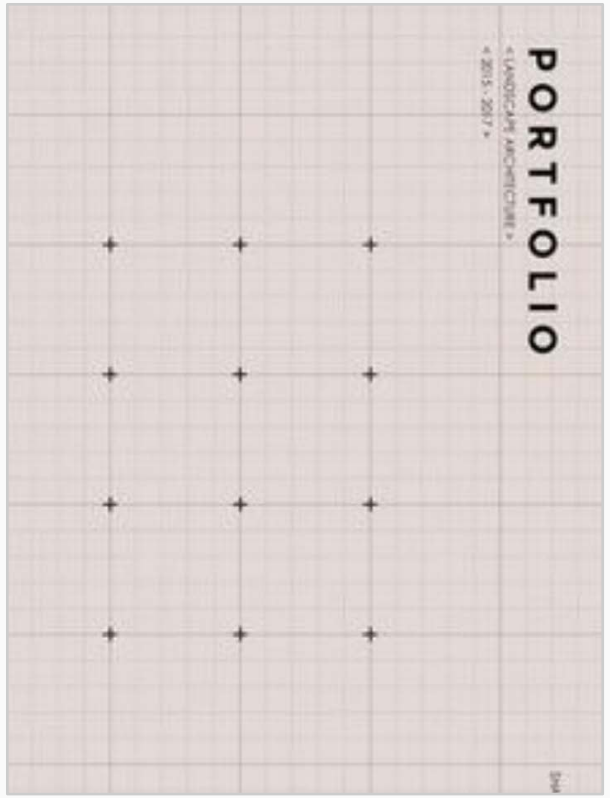
KEY PRINCIPLES

- Thumbnails spread across the whole field, with no single focal point.
- Variable scale creates rhythm and an implied hierarchy among projects without labels.
- Irregular spacing should feel curated. Proximity implies a relationship.
- The title floats among the images as one element, not in a separate type zone.

COVER TYPE 06

Grid / Pattern System

A repeating geometric motif as the visual identity.





Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.

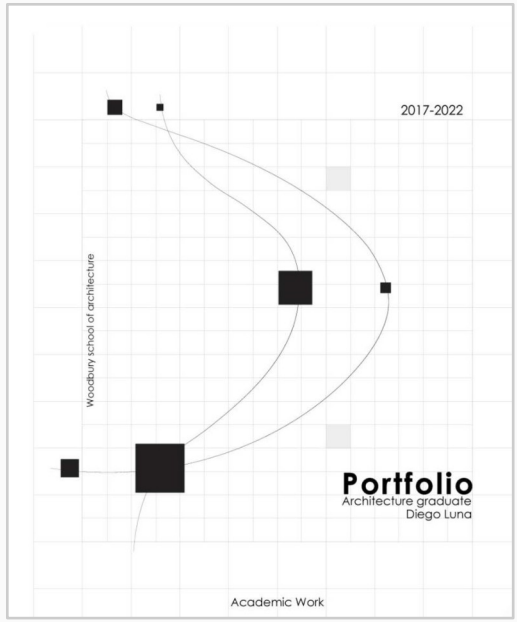
KEY PRINCIPLES

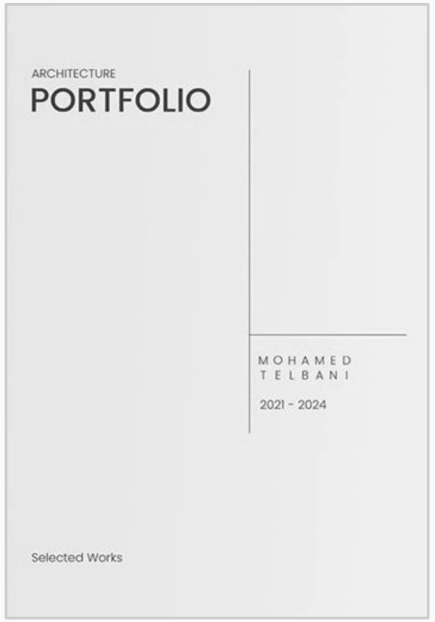
- One small unit, such as a cross, dot, plus mark, or tick, repeats at equal intervals across the field.
- Letter-spacing in the title is calibrated to the grid interval, so type and pattern share one logic.
- Regularity signals systematic thinking and rigor: order over expression.
- The pattern replaces imagery and often references drafting conventions.

COVER TYPE 07

Abstract Line

Freeform curves, intersecting lines, and geometric primitives.







Reference covers: Lecture 09, Cover Typologies.

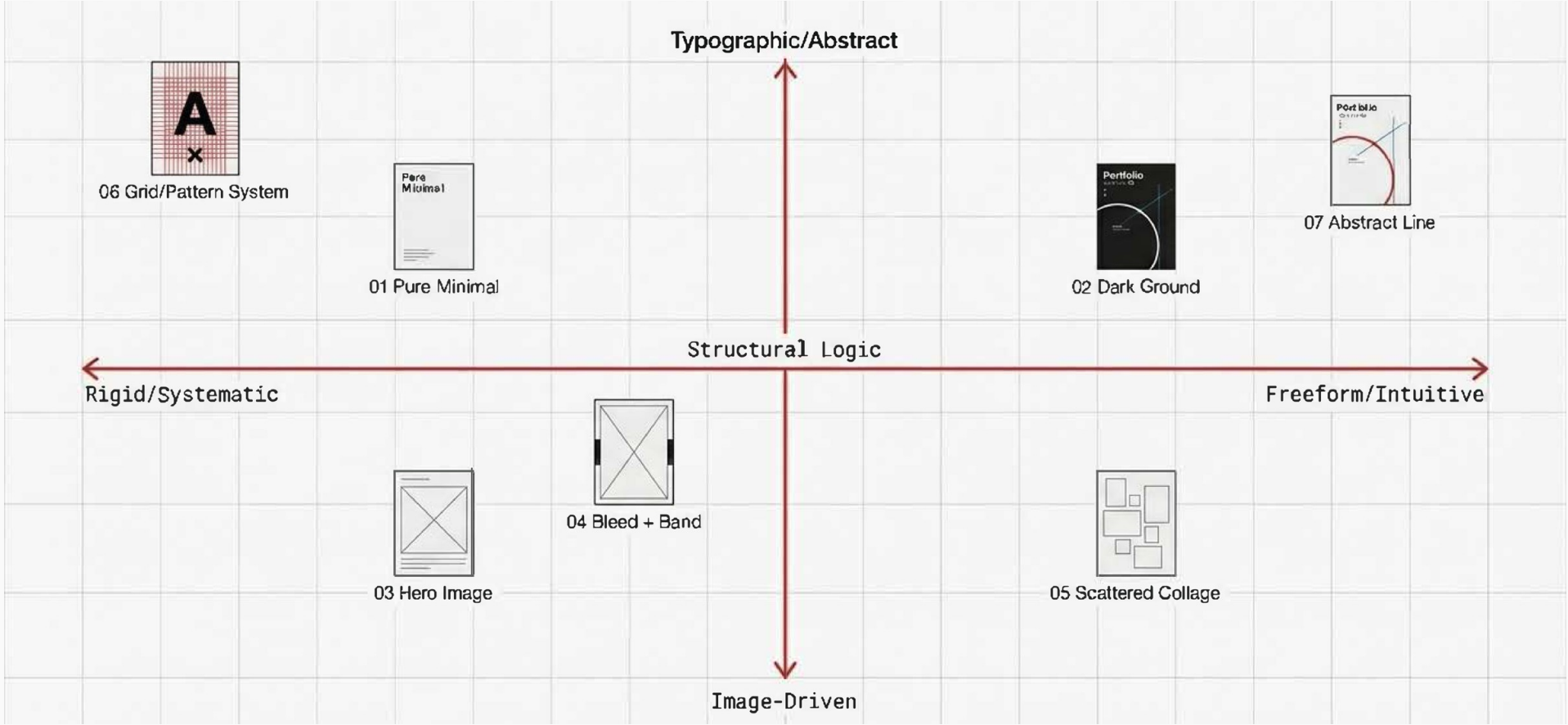
KEY PRINCIPLES

- Two or three geometric elements, such as arcs and lines, with a clear stroke weight hierarchy.
- Intersections work as visual anchors, often marked with a dot or a date.
- The text sits in the quiet zone, the negative space the geometry leaves.
- Freeform and deliberate, not systematic. Every element is a considered decision.

COVER

Where the Seven Types Sit

Rigid or freeform, typographic or image-driven. Figure from Lecture 09.



COVER

Choosing Your Cover

Start from what the project argues, then check the cover against the pages inside.

Start from the Red Thread

The choice should reinforce the same Red Thread that runs through the project sequence. Ask what first impression you want to create.

Check the image

If the cover uses one image, it has to represent your strongest or most characteristic project. If one image cannot carry the portfolio, consider type, a pattern, or a collage.

Match the interior

Use the type system from Session 07 and the same baseline and modular grid as the interior spreads. The cover is page one of the system.

Test it small

Your name must read instantly at thumbnail size. Avoid complex backgrounds and low contrast.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

What the Contents Page Does

More than a project list, it is the roadmap of your portfolio.

Structure Overview

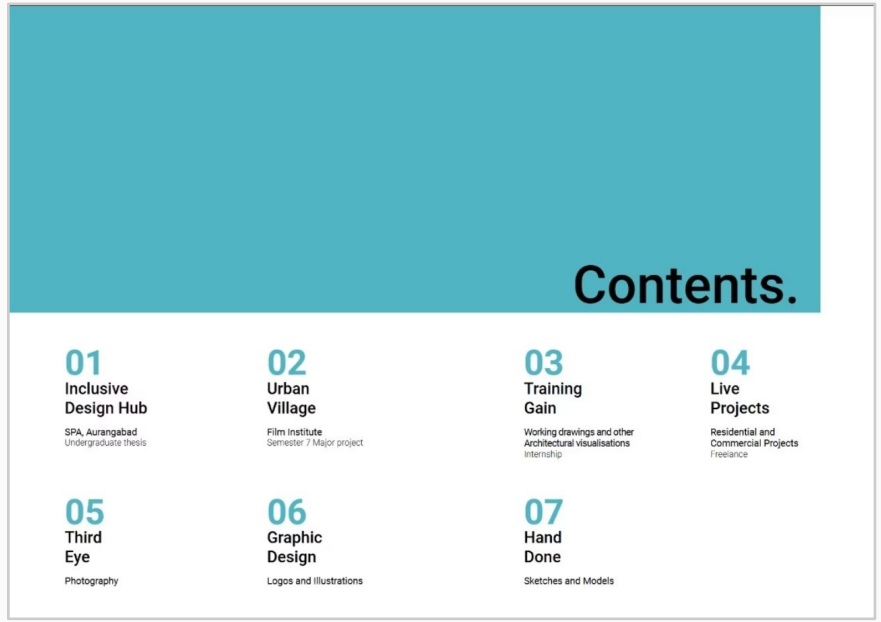
Gives an immediate sense of the scope and organization of your work, so a reviewer grasps its breadth at a glance.

Navigation Tool

Essential for longer portfolios, especially in digital formats. It lets a reviewer jump to specific projects during an interview or review.

Professionalism Signal

A well-designed contents page shows attention to detail and organizational thinking.



A contents page with a color field and numbered entries.

It is not filler between cover and content. Its design teaches the reviewer how to move through your work.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

What Goes on the Page

Titles, page numbers, and supporting details.

Project Titles

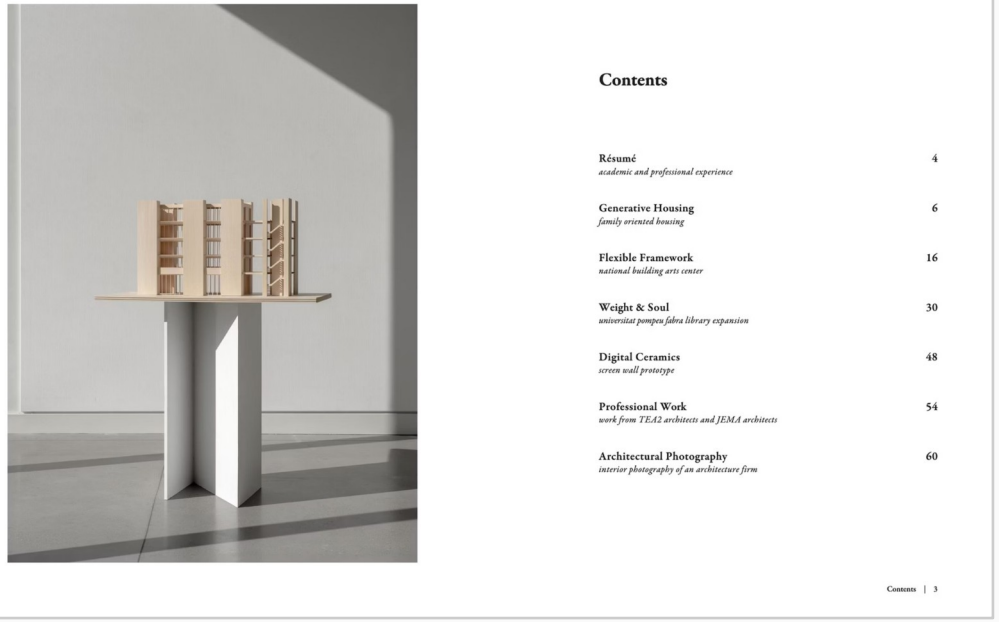
Replace generic names like "Studio Project 1" with conceptual titles, such as "Framing Light," "Urban Interlace," or "Threshold Dynamics." Keep them short, reflect design concepts rather than building types, and consider poetic or metaphorical language.

Page Numbers

Include clear page references, especially in printed or PDF portfolios. For longer projects, consider both starting pages and page ranges.

Supporting Details

Add year, studio name, or instructor sparingly for academic work. Include location for built projects. Keep the hierarchy clear: titles stay primary.



A restrained list beside a single model photograph.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Design Considerations

The contents page has to look like the rest of the portfolio.

Visual Consistency

Your contents typography and grid must connect with the rest of the portfolio. Inconsistency here signals careless attention to detail.

Hierarchy Management

Project titles should dominate the spread, with supporting information clearly secondary. Use size, weight, and spacing to guide the eye.

White Space Strategy

Generous spacing prevents overcrowding and shows your command of layout. White space is active, not empty.

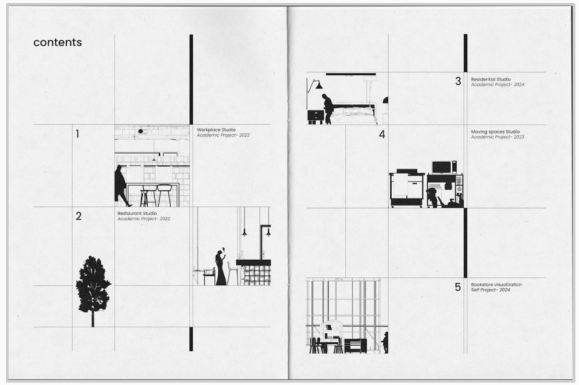


A restrained list: titles first, details smaller.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Six Contents Typologies

Six layouts recur across architecture and design portfolios. Reference spreads from Lecture 10.



01 Illustrated Section Grid



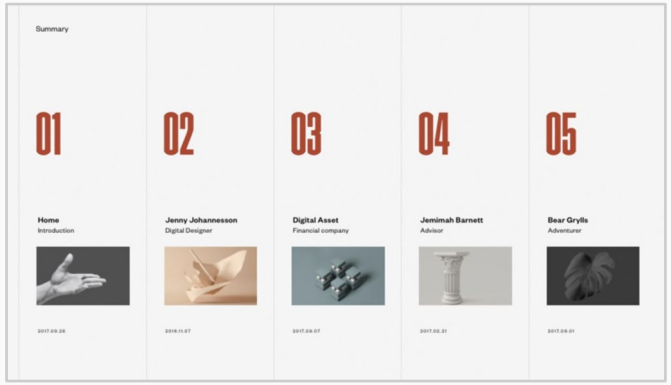
02 Multi-Column Text Index



03 Thumbnail Gallery Row



04 Literary Chapter Index



05 Bold Number Column Cards

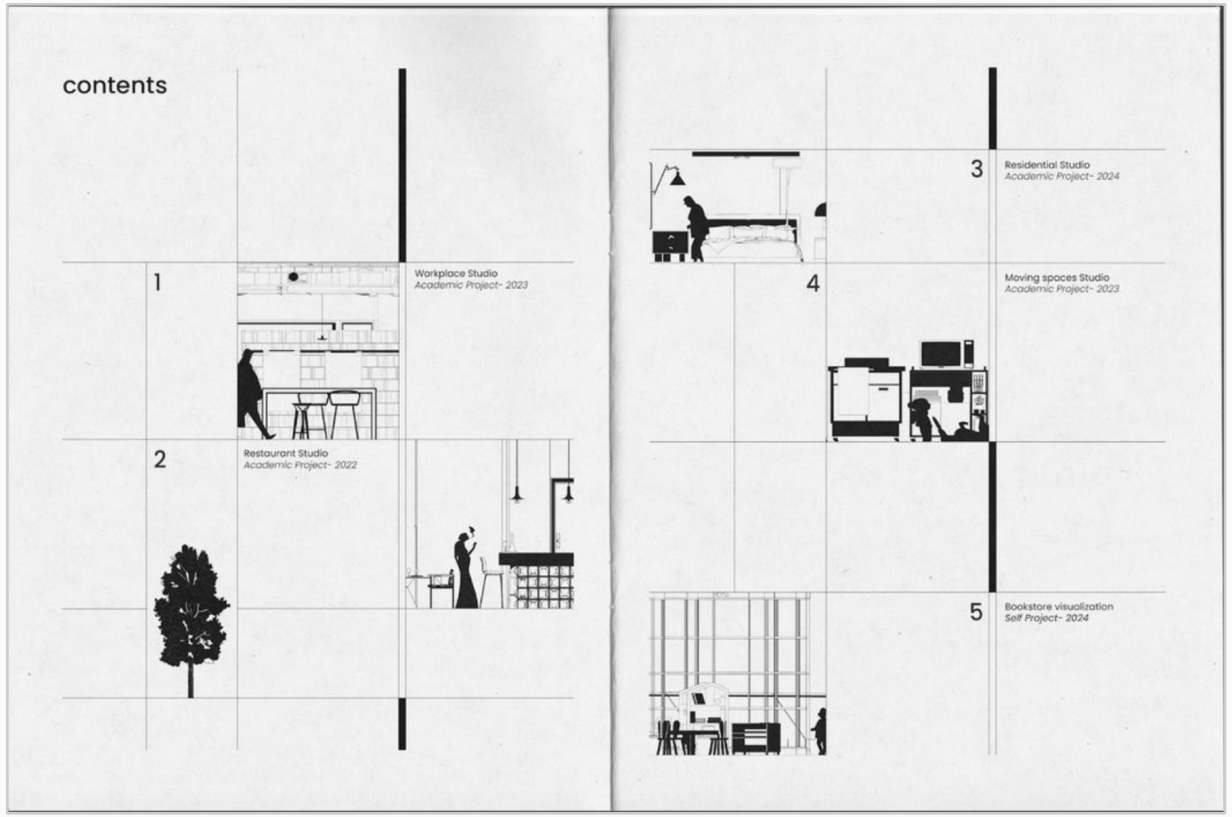


06 Narrative + List Hybrid

CONTENTS TYPE 01

Illustrated Section Grid

Architectural vignettes in a modular grid, separated by bold vertical dividers.



MODULAR GRID · IMAGE-LED · TWO-PAGE SPREAD · VERTICAL DIVIDERS

STRUCTURE

A two-page spread divided into equal columns by thick black rules. Each column has a black and white architectural silhouette at the top with project details stacked below.

HIERARCHY

Oversized section numbers anchor each column. Project title, institution, and page number follow in descending weight.

BEST FOR

Architecture-focused portfolios with 4 to 8 major projects that can be represented by iconic silhouettes or section drawings.

CONTENTS TYPE 02

Multi-Column Text Index

A purely typographic, information-dense index modeled on editorial design.



TEXT ONLY · MULTI-COLUMN · EDITORIAL · INFORMATION DENSE

STRUCTURE

Three columns per page, with entries in numbered sequence. Each entry cascades through category, institution, bold project title, description, collaborators, and page number.

HIERARCHY

Typographic weight and size only: bold titles, regular descriptions, light credits. No decoration.

BEST FOR

Portfolios with many projects (10 or more) or extensive details for each entry, especially academic or research-heavy work.

CONTENTS TYPE 03

Thumbnail Gallery Row

A single row of equally sized thumbnails, with plenty of whitespace.



HORIZONTAL STRIP · IMAGE-LED · WHITESPACE · MINIMAL TEXT

STRUCTURE

One horizontal row of uniformly sized project images across the page width. Page numbers and bold project titles sit directly beneath each thumbnail.

HIERARCHY

Images are the entry point. Text is minimal: project name and location.

BEST FOR

Portfolios with 5 to 7 visually distinct projects, where a single image can represent each body of work.

CONTENTS TYPE 04

Literary Chapter Index

Oversized serif page numbers and letter-spaced headings, a book-design approach.



SERIF TYPE · LARGE NUMERALS · BOOK DESIGN · LETTERSPACING

STRUCTURE

Large serif page numbers (11, 91, 155) at the top of each entry, then letter-spaced section headings in capitals, then italic names and titles.

HIERARCHY

The numeral is the anchor, both a navigation aid and a compositional element. Letter-spacing gives weight without bold.

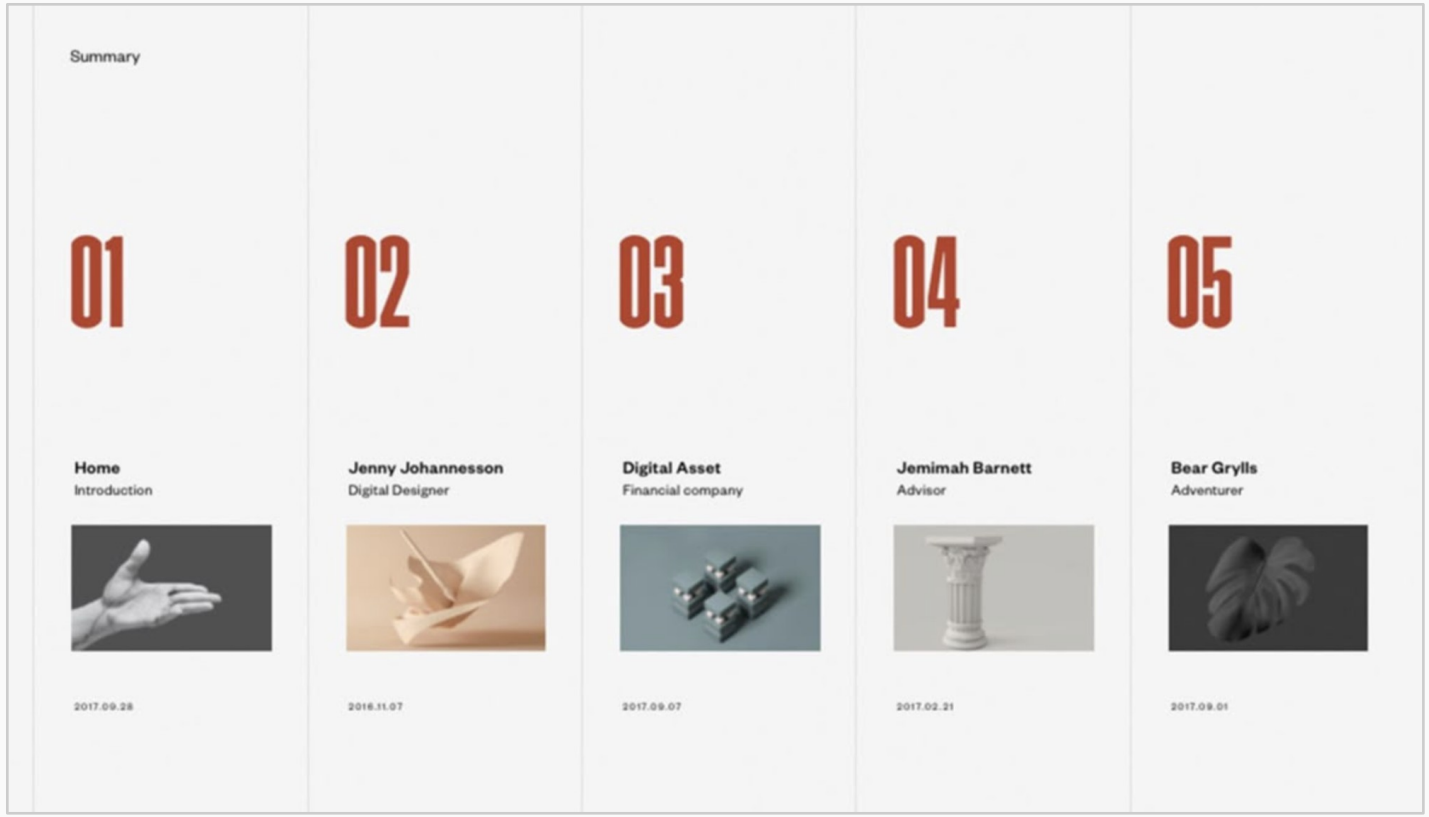
BEST FOR

Portfolios organized as monographs, thematic collections, or work with significant written or theoretical components.

CONTENTS TYPE 05

Bold Number Column Cards

Vertical columns with oversized colored numbers, thumbnails, and details.



COLUMN CARDS · ACCENT COLOR · MAGAZINE STYLE · VERTICAL RULES

STRUCTURE

Vertical columns divided by thin rules. Each column is a card with an oversized colored number (01 to 05), bold name, role, thumbnail, and date.

HIERARCHY

The large number dominates, then the bold title, then lighter details. The thumbnail adds variety inside a strict grid.

BEST FOR

A small, curated set of projects (3 to 6), especially those that emphasize people, roles, or process alongside final work.

CONTENTS TYPE 06

Narrative + List Hybrid

A two-page spread pairing a statement or essay page with a contents list.



TWO-PAGE SPREAD · NARRATIVE · ESSAY + LIST · ACCENT HEADER

STRUCTURE

The left page has an essay with an architectural drawing. The right page is a contents list with bold titles, subtitles, and right-aligned page numbers under an accent header.

HIERARCHY

The essay gives the conceptual framing (why). The list gives navigation (where). The accent header bridges the two.

BEST FOR

Portfolios that emphasize process, narrative, or a conceptual framework, especially thesis work with a strong design statement.

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Contents Typology Matrix

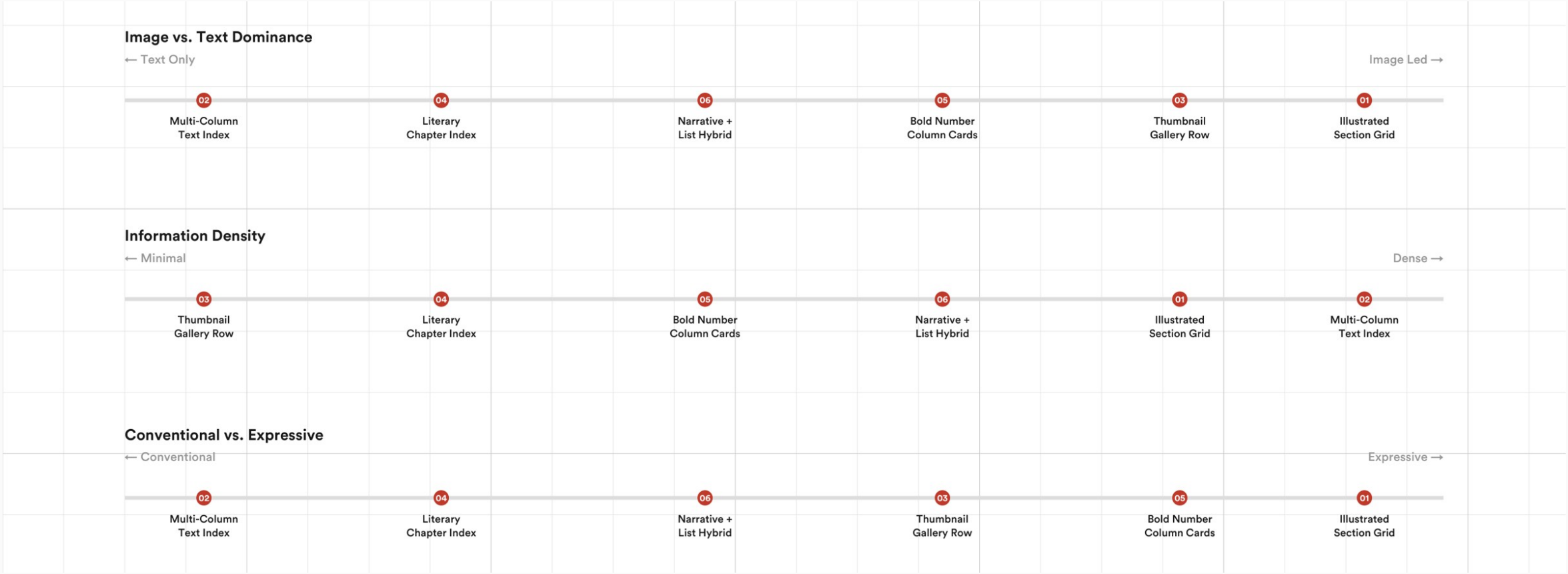
Structure and best use, side by side.

Typology	Approach	Best for
01 Illustrated Section Grid	Modular grid with architectural vignettes as the main navigation	4 to 8 projects with strong visual identities
02 Multi-Column Text Index	Dense typographic layout with no images	10 or more projects; academic or research contexts
03 Thumbnail Gallery Row	One image strip with maximum whitespace	5 to 7 visually distinct projects; clean aesthetic
04 Literary Chapter Index	Large serif numerals and letter-spaced headings	Thematic, essay-driven, or theoretical work
05 Bold Number Column Cards	Vertical cards with oversized accent numbers and thumbnails	3 to 6 curated projects; profile-driven
06 Narrative + List Hybrid	Essay page plus contents list	Thesis portfolios with a strong design narrative

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Where the Six Types Sit

Image or text, minimal or dense, conventional or expressive. Figure from Lecture 10.



SYSTEM

One Numbering System

The format matters less than the commitment to one system.

Convention	How it works
Academic portfolios	Number from the cover onward.
Professional portfolios	Begin numbering after the front matter.
Front matter and projects	Roman numerals mark introductory pages. Arabic numerals mark project pages.

Pick one system and apply it without exception. Inconsistent numbering signals a portfolio assembled in haste, whatever the quality of the work inside.

EXAMPLE

One System Across Projects

Case Study 02: the same title-page format for both projects.



Generative Housing

Mixed Use, Multi-Family Housing
St. Louis, Missouri

Generative housing, a multi-family, mixed use housing project occupies one city block of Downtown West, St. Louis, and aims to counter contemporary multi-family development trends being built across the city of St. Louis. Trends that emphasize private amenities over public space, parking access over retail access, and maximizing unit counts over maximizing livability. These trends lead to housing projects that become isolated enclaves "accessible only by car" within the city and give little back to the neighborhoods where they are placed.

The Generative Housing proposal attempts to counter these issues through a number of architectural strategies. First, the project is designed as a thin ribbon of housing that meanders through the site in strategic ways to generate public plaza spaces. Each plaza serves a specific purpose, whether it be for organized sport, playground space, or gardening space. Second, the project provides units that are larger than the average unit available in St. Louis. The average unit size in the proposal is approximately 1800 square feet, which is the size of a typical single-family home in the city. Apartments are designed for families and growth versus for young professionals and quick profits. Finally, the housing buries parking and limits the number of parking spots in an effort to encourage diverse transportation modalities. Locating parking underground opens up the ground floor for retail and amenity spaces to invite residents of the building and city inside.

Professors: Adrian Luchini
Washington University in St. Louis
Fall 2022

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Generative Housing | 7

Generative Housing



Flexible Framework

National Building Arts Center
St. Louis, Missouri

The National Building Art Center, as it currently stands, is an archive for architectural and building trades artifacts and literature that have been acquired throughout the United States. Many of the artifacts within the collection originate from the city of St. Louis and relate to the city's industrial past. A past that made heavy use of masonry and cast iron techniques that are beginning to fade in modern construction. Flexible Framework is a building arts center that contains exhibition, archive, education, and maker space that serves the National Building Arts Center of St. Louis, Missouri.

Tasked with housing the diverse programmatic requirements of the Building Arts Center, the design of the new structure is composed of a timber framework capable of hosting a multitude of functions. The stable, structural framework acts as a matrix upon which elements can be attached to; gantry cranes, curtains, shelving systems, displays, operable doors, and more are able to fit within the framework and be applied in specific ways to address specific needs. Long spans, operability, concrete, heavy timber, and ceramics–spatial and material strategies that relate to St. Louis's industrial architecture–are employed in unique ways that are both cognizant of the industry that created St. Louis and anticipant of a new age of production.

Professor: Kelley Van Dyck Murphy
Washington University in St. Louis
Spring 2021

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Flexible Framework | 17

Flexible Framework

The same typographic system, image placement, and text structure on both. A reviewer who meets the second divider already knows where to find the statement, the credits, and the image.

DISCUSSION

Your Cover and Contents

Talk these through in your cohort breakout.

UNDERGRAD (44611)

Does your cover need to admit you're a student, or is it fine that it doesn't? What is the minimum viable complete portfolio for someone entering the field for the first time?

GRAD (56995)

Does your cover read as a working designer's, not a student's? Is this ready to send to an employer tomorrow? If not, name the single blocking issue.